

Improved Miners challenge A-State in 3-game series

By BOB JACOBSEN

At the College Baseball Coaches convention in Chicago this past winter, guest speaker and American League Manager of the Year Chuck Tanner gave much of the credit for his (Tanner's) success to one man — Andy Cohen.

It had to be good timing.

Cohen, who managed Tanner in the minor leagues, brings unquestionably the nation's most improved collegiate baseball team into town tonight as his Texas-El Paso Miners meet Arizona State in the first of a three-game Western Athletic Conference Southern Division series.

The Sun Devils, 34-5 overall and 3-0 in WAC play, will send ace Eddie Bane (7-1) to the mound against the Miners, 17-11 and 2-1 in league action after a pair of wins over New Mexico last week.

Due to water being released into the Salt River, causing limited access to Municipal Stadium, game times for tonight and tomorrow night have been moved back to 8 o'clock. The first game of tomorrow's twinbill is still 1 p.m. with Jim Umbarger (2-1) set to hurl, and Jim Otten (6-1) scheduled tomorrow night. There will be no radio broadcast of any of the three games.

Most improved in the nation, you say? They have to be. The Miners were probably the worst team (?) in the country last year.

Examples: (1) ASU 30, UTEPO; (2) ASU 16, UTEP 0; (3) ASU 12, UTEP 1; (4) ASU 8, UTEP 0; and (5) ASU 10, UTEP 4. Of course, losing to last year's great Sun Devil club was no disgrace, but the Texans finished 12-39 overall and 1-17 in WAC play, beating the Lobos on the next-to-last day.

"I just hope the players forget last year," said ASU coach Jim Brock, "and keep that out of their minds. We'll have to beat this year's UTEP club on the field.

"The league is much more even this year. There'll be some upsets along the way."

The Devils have won 26 straight in WAC regular season play, last losing to UTEP in May, 1971, and have captured 36 of their last 39 in the conference. Two of those three defeats were to the Miners, and, in fact, the Texans won two games in each of 1971 and 1972.



SUN DEVIL LINEUP (WAC averages in parentheses)

SS—Bump Wills (.357); LF—Dennis Kendrick (.333); CF—Gary Atwell (.200); RF—Dick Harris (.286); 1B—Clay Westlake (.538); C—Clint Myers (.417); DH—Rawlings (.167) or Kenneth (.400); 3B—Oscarson (.500) or T. Sain (.200); 2B—Bill Berger (.417); and Bane (1-0, 2.00 ERA); Umbarger (0-0, 10.12); and Otten (1-0, 2.79).

UTEP is led by outfielder Eloy Alvarado and infielder Mark Miller at the plate with .296 marks, while first baseman Barry Alburtis has whacked four home runs — two key clouts against UNM last week.

Sophomore righthander Bob Knox is the top Miner hurler with a 3-0 record and a near-unbelievable 0.00 ERA in 24 1/3 innings. Freshman righthander Jeff Hogan is 4-0 (2.08 ERA); sophomore lefthander Ray Greggerson 3-1 (3.07); and freshman lefthander Mike Hilton 1-2 (0.79).

And as Cohen says, "We have good hitting, good team speed, our defense is much improved, and we fair depth. But the key to our success has been our pitching staff — they're young, but get the job done."

Brock will start his usual seven, with the up-for-grabs spots at third with either Jeff Oscarson and Tommy Sain, and at designated hitter with either Mike Rawlings, a right-handed swinger, or Mike Kenneth, who hits from the left side. And he also hopes for a quick game.

"If Andy cooperates," he said, "I promise the fans a 1:49 game. Last week was ridiculous (when it took some 9:17 to play three games vs. UA)."